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On The Ropes

BOB LEE KNOWS his place at the University of New Mexico. He's not a politician or an administrator. Lee's duties for the past 11 years have been to coach the Lobo baseball team and never during his tenure has UNM had a losing season.

Yet, there's a rope creeping out of Athletic Director Lavon McDonald's office ready to whirl around Lee's neck and cut off his lifeline. Word has it that if New Mexico does not escape the upcoming Western Athletic Conference season with nine victories, Lee can expect to join the long line of people down at the unemployment office.

And if that's the case, Lee undoubtedly will be hanging from the tree limb outside McDonald's window. Lee has as much chance of winning nine games as the University of Texas at El Paso has of capturing the WAC title. It's next to impossible.

"Nothing is impossible," says Lee. "You can't pick the games you will win or lose. You do the things you do best and if you do them well and perhaps the other team doesn't quite function right, you can probably win. You don't win too many games. It's usually the other team that loses the game."

To conceivably win the quoted number told to Lee by McDonald earlier in the season, New Mexico would have to sweep its six games from UTEP and hope for at least three wins over powerful Arizona State and Arizona.

Easier said than done, though.

In 1975, New Mexico split with the Miners by winning at home and losing on the road. When it came to the Arizona schools, the Lobos were blanked 12-0. "We could have won three or four games with the Arizona schools," recalls Lee. "We lost three one-run games and lost one extra inning game. If we would have done this or if we would have done that we might have won. If, if, if. Isn't that what sports is all about?"

TO MAKE THE situation worse, New Mexico will be appearing at Dudley Field to open the WAC season against UTEP with a single game Friday and two Saturday with almost a new outfit from the '75 club which posted a 28-26 overall record and 3-15 in the WAC.

"We lost 19 people and although we're 22-10 so far we've had our ups and downs like a roller coaster, something that should be expected with an inexperienced ball club," said Lee.

Why, suddenly, after so many seasons over the .500 level is Lee's head placed on the chopping blocks?

One story which circulated around the New Mexico campus had McDonald saying baseball would be exterminated from the major sports programs. The WAC's only requirement is that a conference member participate in four major sports.

"I've been told that I'm expected to win nine games by McDonald but I'm sure there's not too much teeth in that anymore," said Lee of the situation. "I was also told a couple of weeks ago that baseball would be dropped but that changed as suddenly as it was thought up."

"I can't keep up with all the insides. I'm trying to coach a baseball team."

A FEW WEEKS past, Lee decided it was time to know the situation at New Mexico. Having been told his position was on the line, Lee was content to sit out the season without telling anybody or putting any pressure on his players.

But after McDonald mentioned the possibility of eliminating the sport from New Mexico's budget, Lee took action himself.

"I didn't want to put pressure on my kids but it was time people found out what the hell was going on," said Lee. "I've been here 11 years and never had a losing season. We hold a considerable winning edge over any club we've ever played with the exception of the two Arizona schools and from 1968-72 we played .500 ball with Arizona."

The chain of events actually began after the 1972 season when Arizona decided to upgrade its program and Lee found his funds and scholarships slowly diminishing.

"Baseball is not given enough funds to support a solid program," said Lee of the New Mexico situation. "Before the NCAA cut the limit of baseball scholarships to 13, both the Arizona schools had around 25 full scholarships. We've never had half that and I know Andy (Cohen, UTEP coach) hasn't either."

It's not conceivable to see how New Mexico or even the University of Texas at El Paso are expected to compete with two major league farm clubs in Arizona and Arizona State. How any athletic director can expect a program the size of New Mexico's to compete against those schools is anybody's wonder.